

## EPIC FORTIFICATION

# THE GREAT WALL OF CHINA

**The longest defensive fortification ever built, the Great Wall of China protected northern China from incursions by mounted warriors from the steppe. First constructed over 2,000 years ago and rebuilt in the 15th century, it was a piece of military infrastructure on an unprecedented scale.**

China's settled civilization was always vulnerable to the nomadic, bow-wielding horsemen living in the vast spaces of inner Asia to the north and west. The wealth of Chinese cities and agricultural lands had long attracted these highly mobile steppe raiders, from the Xiongnu and the Jurchen to the Mongols and the Manchu.

Qin Shi Huang, known as the First Emperor because of his unification of China in 221 BCE, created the original Great Wall by joining up a number of existing fortifications, some already 500 years old. Built mostly of packed earth, with some wood and stone, over successive centuries the Qin Wall was only partially and sporadically maintained, leaving northern China exposed to pillage.

## THE NEED FOR DEFENCES

The Ming dynasty came to power in the 14th century, and represented a reassertion of Chinese national pride after a period of rule by Mongol conquerors. At first, the Ming were expansionist in outlook, seeking to extend Chinese territory by sea into the Indian Ocean, and by land into Central Asia. But ambitions to subdue the steppe tribes came to a halt in 1449, when Emperor Zhengtong was defeated and captured by Oirat Mongols on the frontier at the Battle of Tumu. As well as this military disaster, the need for protection against the steppe horsemen had become more acute since 1421, when the northern city of Beijing was made the official Ming capital, instead of the more southerly city of Nanjing. Beijing was virtually a frontier town, and was critically exposed to attack. However, the steppe warriors' bows

and blades, though deadly when used in a pitched battle, would be unsuited to assailing fortifications.

In 1474, work began on a new Great Wall made from brick and stone, strong enough to withstand attack by the horsemen. Built mostly along the line of the old Qin Wall, in many places the remains of the original earth structure were used as foundations. Vast resources of human labour were devoted to building 5,650 km (3,510 miles) of fortification, much of it across difficult terrain. The function of this wall was partly symbolic – to mark the territory in which Chinese civilization held sway. But it was mainly a practical, utilitarian military structure. As a physical barrier, it was sufficiently solid to repel the parties of horsemen armed with composite bows and bladed weapons. Sturdy fortresses were sited along its length, protecting key towns, mountain passes, or river crossings. More than 7,000 lookout towers enabled small garrisons of soldiers armed with pikes, swords, and crossbows to keep watch for intruders, and signal for reinforcements in case of attack. The walkway along the top of the wall allowed for the rapid movement of infantry from barracks or forts to any point that was under threat.

The wall outlasted the Ming dynasty, which disintegrated in the 17th century. The invading Manchu horsemen were only able to conquer China because Chinese General Wu Sangui, guarding the Great Wall at the Shanhai Pass, deliberately opened its gates to allow them through to Beijing. The wall itself remained an effective feat of military engineering.

